

Six Sigma Glossary

Plain-English definitions of every Six Sigma, Lean, and AI term used in this course. Keep it open while you work and use it to verify the 5 percent that matters.

ACW (After-Call Work). the wrap-up time an agent spends after a call ends, logging notes and tasks.

AHT (Average Handle Time). the typical total time to handle one contact, including talk time and after-call work.

Analyze. the third DMAIC phase: play detective and find the root cause of the problem.

Baseline. a numerical snapshot of how a process performs today, flaws and all, measured before you change anything.

CL (Center Line). the average line on a control chart; the process's typical level.

Common cause variation. the ordinary, random wiggle a stable process always has; leave it alone.

Control. the fifth DMAIC phase: lock in the gains with standard work and monitoring so they last.

Control chart. a run chart with a center line and upper/lower control limits; inside the limits is noise, outside is a signal to investigate.

Cpk. process capability index: how well a process fits inside its limits. Higher is better (1.33 is a common benchmark; 1.1 is below it).

CTQ (Critical to Quality). the few things the customer cares about most; what "good" means to them.

DMAIC. the five-phase improvement roadmap: Define, Measure, Analyze, Improve, Control.

Define. the first DMAIC phase: understand and scope the problem and write the charter.

DOWNTIME. memory aid for the eight wastes: Defects, Overproduction, Waiting, Non-utilized talent, Transportation, Inventory, Motion, Extra-processing.

DPMO (Defects Per Million Opportunities). a defect rate scaled to one million chances; lets you compare very different processes.

Fishbone (Ishikawa) diagram. a cause-and-effect diagram shaped like a fish skeleton that organizes possible causes by category so you think in every direction.

Five Whys. ask "why" about five times in a row to drill from a symptom down to a fundamental root cause.

FCR (First Contact Resolution). the share of issues solved on the customer's first contact, with no follow-up needed.

Gemba. Japanese for "the real place"; "go and see" where the work actually happens instead of guessing from a desk.

Hallucination. when AI confidently states something false as if it were true; the reason you must verify AI's facts.

Histogram. a bar chart of how often values fall into ranges; shows the shape (center, spread, skew, peaks) that an average hides.

IVR (Interactive Voice Response). the automated phone menu ("press 1 for...") that routes callers before they reach a person.

Jidoka. a Lean pillar: build in quality by stopping automatically at the moment a defect appears, born from Toyota's self-stopping loom.

Kaizen. small, continuous improvement; the daily habit of making the work a little better than yesterday. No idea is too small.

LCL (Lower Control Limit). the bottom boundary on a control chart; a point below it is a signal.

Lean. a management approach focused on delivering customer value by relentlessly eliminating waste.

LENS. the prompt recipe: Lead with the persona, Establish context, Name the task, Set the format/constraints.

Measure. the second DMAIC phase: establish a fact-based baseline before changing anything.

Necessary waste. a step the customer would not pay for but that the business currently cannot avoid (e.g., a required inspection).

Pareto chart. sorted bars plus a cumulative line that reveal the "vital few" categories causing most of the problem (the 80/20 rule).

Process map. a picture of how work flows, in boxes and arrows, where waste hides in the gaps, handoffs, and rework loops.

Project charter. the one-page contract that defines the problem, goal, scope, customer, and team for a project.

Pure waste. a step the customer would not pay for and the business does not need; remove it.

Response plan. the human system around a control chart: who watches, how often, what counts as a signal, and what to do first when one appears.

Run chart. a simple line chart with time on the x-axis that reveals trends and shifts a snapshot cannot.

Sigma level. a measure of process quality; higher sigma means fewer defects (Six Sigma aims for 3.4 defects per million).

SIPOC. a one-page overview of a process: Suppliers, Inputs, Process, Outputs, Customers.

Special cause variation. an unusual change with a specific, nameable reason; a signal worth investigating.

SOP (Standard Operating Procedure). the written document that captures the one best way to do a task so everyone follows it.

Standard work. the single documented best way to do a job, followed by all; it locks in gains and eases training.

Takt time. the pace of customer demand: how often you must finish one unit to keep up with what customers want.

UCL (Upper Control Limit). the top boundary on a control chart; a point above it is a signal.

Value (value-added). a step the customer would happily pay for because it changes the product or service in a way they want.

Variation. the natural fact that no process repeats exactly; managing it is the heart of Six Sigma.

VOC (Voice of the Customer). the customer's feedback in their own words; the white belt compiles it, higher belts theme it.

White belt. the entry-level Six Sigma role: the local expert, data gatherer, documentation engine, and early-warning system.